

Employer-Focused Interventions to Reduce Age Discrimination Against Older Workers

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1. Abstract

This study addresses an important but neglected topic by investigating whether employers' generational cohorts (**Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, Generation Z**) are associated with differences in age-based discrimination.

Drawing on System Justification Theory, we examine the psychological mechanisms that may help explain differences across generational cohorts in rationalizations for discrimination.

Pilot data and expected results suggest that younger employers may exhibit stronger bias against older candidates but may also be more responsive to theory-based de-biasing interventions.

2. Introduction

Phenomenon

The “silver tsunami”—the rapid aging of the global workforce—is no longer a future forecast but an unfolding reality (Rudolph et al., 2021; Lyons et al., 2015). This irreversible demographic shift is not only changing **“who works,” but also reshaping “how organizations work”** (Kooij et al., 2020; Waldman, 2021; Joshi et al., 2011).

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Research Gap

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However, we question this prevailing assumption by suggesting that a neglected factor—**the generational cohort membership of employers themselves**—may be associated with differences in age-related attitudes and behaviors.

If these differences shape how they perceive and implement age-inclusive policies, have we underestimated the role of generational cohort differences in both the formation of and intervention in age discrimination?

Our work seeks to examine **how differences across employers' generational cohorts may influence the design and implementation of anti-bias interventions targeting older employees**.

We further aim to explore how organizations can develop interventions that bridge, rather than exacerbate, generational divides.

3. Methods

Method

Sample

Across both studies, data were collected from approximately **300 real-world job openings (Study 1)** and **200 HR professionals (Study 2)**.

An a priori power analysis conducted using G*Power 3.1 indicated that a minimum of 180 observations per study would provide adequate statistical power ($f = 0.25$, $\alpha = 0.05$, $1 - \beta = 0.80$) to detect medium-sized effects. The combined dataset allows examination of both behavioral (field) and attitudinal (experimental) evidence of generational differences.

Research Design and Procedure

The audit experiment employed a 2 (applicant age: young vs. older) $\times$ 4 (employer generational cohort: Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, Generation Z) factorial design.

The primary outcome variable was the interview invitation rate (callback rate), with covariates including applicant gender and job type. The intervention experiment used a 2 (applicant age: young vs. older) $\times$ 3 (intervention type: de-biasing, brief attitude, control) between-subjects design.

Measurement

Résumés were matched on qualifications, skills, and work experience but varied in graduation year and career length to signal applicant age, representing **candidates below versus above 50 years old, a commonly used threshold for defining older applicants in labor market research (Sinclair et al., 2023)**.

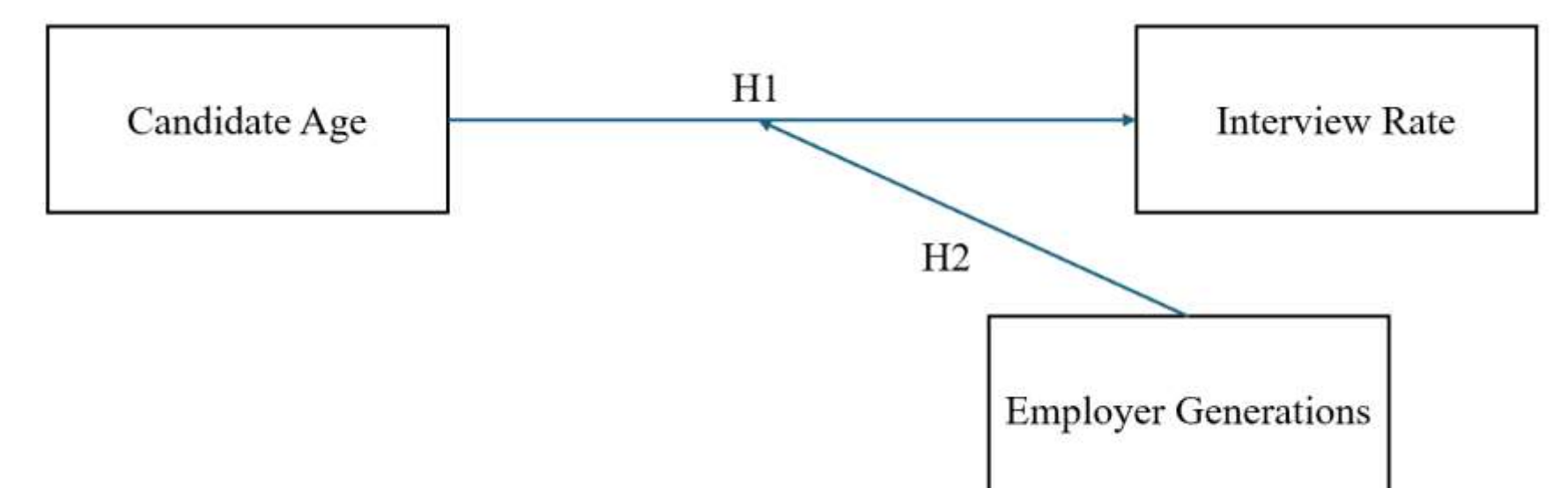
Following research in organizational demography, generational characteristics of organizations can be approximated through leadership cohort composition and founding period, as these factors shape managerial values, HR practices, and organizational culture. Accordingly, Employer generational cohort was estimated to be **using company-level proxy indicators**:

- the average age of senior managers identified through LinkedIn or company websites.
- company founding year
- industry-level HR demographic data.

These indicators were combined to assign employers to generational cohorts (Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, Generation Z). Participants evaluated four résumés that varied by applicant age and gender after receiving one of the interventions delivered via text or multimedia lasting 10–15 minutes. Post-task measures included the **Ageism Attitude Scale (AAS) and an age-focused Implicit Association Test (IAT; Greenwald, McGhee, & Schwartz, 1998) to assess implicit bias**.

4. Hypotheses

Study1: Audit Experiment



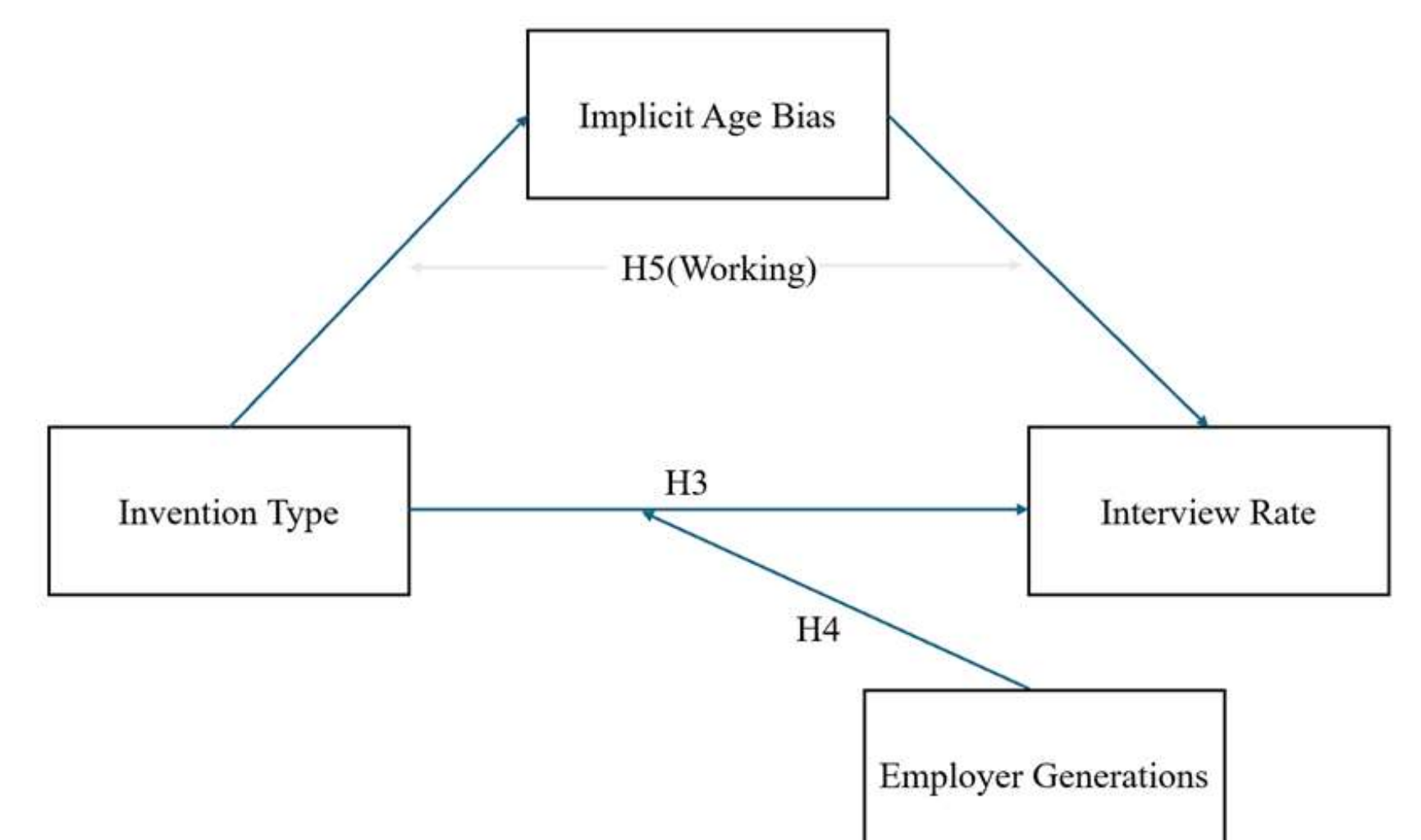
H1: Older candidates receive fewer interview invitations than younger candidates.

H2: Employer generational cohort moderates the effect of candidate age on interview invitations.

(Specifically, Millennials and Generation Z employers show stronger age discrimination against older candidates compared with Baby Boomers and Generation X.)

[*Note: Candidate gender will be included as an exploratory variable to examine potential age-gender intersectional discrimination.]

Study2: Intervention Experiment



H3: Interventions increase hiring intentions for older candidates compared to the control group.

H4: Employer generational cohort moderates intervention effects. Interventions are more effective for Millennials and Generation Z than for Baby Boomers and Generation X.

H5 (Working hypothesis): Implicit age bias mediates the effect of interventions on hiring intentions. Interventions reduce implicit age bias (measured via IAT), which in turn increases hiring intentions for older candidates.

5. Pilot Test Result

Callback data (Study 1) and attitudinal measures (Study 2) were analyzed using SPSS 27, with logistic regression, linear mixed-effects models, and **PROCESS** used to test interaction and mediation effects.

Pilot test results support the hypothesized patterns: younger employers (Millennials and Generation Z) showed stronger bias against older candidates in hiring decisions, but they also responded more positively to de-biasing interventions, exhibiting increased intentions to hire older candidates.

Older generations displayed lower baseline bias and smaller intervention effects, consistent with the moderation predictions (H2, H4).

6. Limitations

- ① This study is based on preliminary and pre-experimental data and captures only short-term attitudinal feedback. ;
- ② Study 1 inferred employer generation using organisational indicators (such as year of company establishment and executive age structure); such proxy indicators may not fully reflect the actual generational identity of hiring managers.

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Bio: I am currently completing my undergraduate degree in Entrepreneurship and Innovation at HKBU. I will be joining LSE later this year to pursue my postgraduate studies in Organizational Behaviour.